

DIGITISATION, EDUCATION AND DEBATING: TAKING FORWARD THE IDEAS AND INSPIRATION OF ALFRED SNIDER INTO THE DIGITAL AGE

Mike Douse, *Educational Advisory Services to the
European Union*

This paper commences with an assessment of the present status of “speaking” in schools. It then addresses the impact of digitisation on education and concludes with a view on how the latter can and should transform the former, heralding the ‘debate’ as the essential pedagogy. Being part of a tribute to Alfred Snider, it acknowledges his massive contribution to the understanding and effective application of debate in the academic setting. Although our paths overlapped geographically here and there (in Bangladesh, for example, where I know from first-hand experience that his influence has been both positive and significant), my evidence is drawn predominantly at the secondary school level and from the British Isles, the Antipodes and much of the developing world (I have not debated in the United States since a hectic tour of seventeen universities, plus two in Canada, in 1963).

Essentially, digitisation is profoundly changing the academic setting worldwide, necessitating and making possible an entirely fresh approach to education with – I contend and welcome – well-informed and open debating at its heart. It is this massive and universal development that, in the context of recognising and taking forward Professor Snider’s ideas and approaches, is addressed below. Through his inspiration, the educational significance of the academic debate is widely recognised: my present task is to set that

recognition in the context of the massive changes to education at all levels and in all countries, made both feasible and inevitable by digitisation.

The Silent Majority

From the World School Students Debating Championships (in which some forty countries take part annually, competing of course for the “Alfred Snider Trophy”), through national and city or county contests (some 22,000 secondary students participated in last year’s Speak Out Challenge in London, England), to school- and university-level speakers and debaters clubs, there are massive (and under-reported) developments in academic debating worldwide and at all levels. Gradually and belatedly, the focus is broadening from contests involving only the best and keenest orators towards training and participation for a wider range of students. Nevertheless, the typical pattern, in the UK, Ireland and other school systems with which I am most familiar, remains one of formal competitions for those interested in debating, alongside specialist attention – when available – for those with identified speech problems.

Thus the review of young people with speech, language and communication needs (SLCN), led by John Bercow, Mr. Speaker of the British House of Commons (Bercow, 2008), was widely perceived by the media as dealing mainly with those young people who needed speech therapists. In fact, it called for upgrading the standards of spoken communication of all children and adolescents. The Bercow Report addressed how best to enable speech, language and communication services to improve educational outcomes, promote public health, tackle anti-social behaviour and bolster the skills of the workforce. It underlined that oral communication is an essential skill and fundamental

human right, crucial to every child’s ability to access and get the most out of education and life.

In the UK, the Association of Speakers Clubs (ASC) is anxious that these and other initiatives result in all young people becoming able to communicate verbally, confidently and effectively. Toastmasters International has similar aims, albeit focussed upon public speaking rather than debating. Much attention has been given to reports of school-leavers’ literacy and numeracy deficiencies. But a far larger proportion, including many who can handle numbers and write reasonably adequately, are unable to stand up and express themselves orally. Many young people in the workforce report to speakers clubs, and even pay good money to communication coaches, seeking guidance in making presentations, in interview techniques, and in discussion group leadership and participation.

In the majority of workplaces, most communication is oral. Instructions are issued, ideas are thrown around and verbal feedback is forthcoming. Even when the product is in written form – such as a newspaper or an ebook – the content has emerged from discussions, meetings and questioning. From the hospitality industry through to the security services, and from retailing through to medicine and law, and from government service through to the charity sector, the capacity to express oneself orally, to listen intelligently, and to ask and answer questions shrewdly is a crucial proficiency.

Much of what occurs in classrooms and lecture halls, however, is based upon and results in words on pages. The most vital occupational and social skill is not encompassed by the 3Rs (of Reading, Writing and Arithmetic – perhaps ‘oracy’ [the ability to express oneself in and understand spoken language] should become the fourth). While schools have responded

to the vital computer skills requirement, that too engenders hard copy rather than speech. Most homework assignments involve writing or preparation for a written test the following day. Examinations – even those with practical components – are based almost exclusively on the expression of ideas on paper: “orals” tend to be confined to foreign language assessments.

While some of this is inevitable, in that what is spoken is transitory and untransmittable in comparison with that which is written or uploaded, opportunities for helping all students build up their spoken communication skills abound. Schools in Australia and New Zealand, for instance, encourage students to debate historical questions from various perspectives and to make presentations regarding, for example, ecological or health behaviour issues. Every class member is involved, reading speeches is not permitted, and teachers comment and assess each student’s performance taking account of style and persuasiveness as well as content. This might well be a useful model for practices elsewhere.

An International Perspective

My work (for the European Commission, the UK’s Department for International Development, the United Nations Children’s Fund and other development partners) has taken me into classrooms in countries as diverse as Vietnam, St Kitts and Nevis, Malaysia, Kiribati, Somalia, the Republic of South Africa, Nepal and – as already mentioned – Bangladesh. In some instances, and far more than in those British and Irish schools best known to me, adolescent youngsters are able effectively to argue aloud on this work of literature or that aspect of human geography. In many settings I have heard secondary students describing to one

another the purpose, outcomes and significance of the chemistry experiment that they have just performed or contest the meaning and merit of the text that they have studied. Here and there across the world, students are speaking across the curriculum. With imagination, the spoken word may be applied in learning areas which, on the face of it, appear essentially written or printed.

Increasingly, educationalists internationally identify a link between debating and scholastic achievement (see, for example, Mezuk, 2009; Douse, 2014; recent National Forensic League bulletins and, of course, publications by Professor Snider himself). Snider’s evidence and observations on the enhancement of academic performance consequent upon participation in debates correspond to my own experiences and, indeed, to common sense. Attributes such as creativity, self-esteem, information analysis, teamwork, research skills and effective listening all come into play in debating and certainly relate to academic performance. This effect is undoubtedly continuing to occur in Bangladesh where – as already implied – it is acknowledged that Professor Snider kick-started university-level debating and, in his words, this “...will propel these students forward in a way that normal education may not be able to. From the best student to those who are struggling, debating can be of real educational benefit” (Snider, 2015).

It is also the case that “Debating can be used to enhance the teaching of various subjects” (Snider & Schnurer, 2006) and good work has been done on how it may be applied as a classroom technique in a range of disciplines (see Duffin, 2005, for example). There is also a growing recognition of the spoken word as vital to democratic participation (see, for example, the Debating for Democracy website with its evidence

related to Project Pericles, or the British Council's Young Arab Voices programme) Students involved in overseas speaking- and debate-related innovations that I have witnessed have also justified it to me in terms of their being able to join in talk-back radio programmes, to stand up for their rights on school councils, to become participating trade unionists, and to be prepared for the seminar approach at universities.

But back in the British Isles, our pedagogy is still attached to the pen – and, to an increasing extent, the keyboard – rather than to the learners' organs of speech. Perhaps the UK National Curriculum is perceived as too crowded to be dealt with in any radical albeit more rational manner. Inevitably, teachers tend to teach as they themselves were taught, mediated by how they were taught to teach. As with any educational innovation, emphasising the spoken word in current circumstances would need to begin with the teachers, encompassing not only their own training but also their aspirations, morale and dispositions: for some, the very last thing that they'd desire their students to learn would be how to argue effectively.

It is the case, however, that coming generations will spend far more time expressing ideas out loud and listening critically than they will in solving quadratic equations on paper or compiling paragraphs on the significance of this scene in a play or the origins of the Hundred Years War. We cannot afford another generation to whom "making a speech" is as attractive as undergoing root canal surgery. Still less can the individuals involved, whose world of work will be increasingly competitive and whose leisure time opportunities progressively more participative.

Certainly no youngster should leave school unable to enjoy handling mathematical ideas

or with a lack of any love of reading or with an antipathy towards computers. But equally – yes, equally – none should emerge unable to contribute to a discussion, ask questions of political and local government representatives, engage in advocacy, make presentations, give clear verbal instructions and advice, and listen thoughtfully and critically to speeches and statements made by others. Happily, as we move into the Fourth Industrial Age, digitisation necessitates and makes possible a fresh educational approach which – very much in the spirit of Alfred Snider – addresses and provides solutions to these challenges.

Digitisation and *The School*

Over four decades ago, as Foundation Director of Australia's Disadvantaged Schools Program, along with my colleagues I pondered on how the leading ("Great Public" i.e. "Wealthy Independent") schools could assist those serving the nation's most underprivileged communities. Some years later, assessing the UK's Assisted Schools Programme, we wondered how well-funded private colleges could sustain and mentor the most poorly-maintained schools. And, over many more recent years, working with development partners supporting education in some of the world's humblest and most fragile communities, we considered how successful schools in developed countries could somehow link up with those serving the poorest of the poor, inter-continentially and beyond all borders.

Such well-intentioned conjectures are no longer relevant. Linkages and partnerships are as outdated as spirit duplicators and fax machines. Contemporary technology makes feasible – nay essential – an entirely fresh and utterly integrated approach. With digitisation, it is no longer a matter of this well-endowed school assisting this struggling school. Amalgamation

has overtaken assistance, all schools everywhere have become *The School*. Entirely appropriately, development partners including the World Bank, USAID and the European Union, are directing resources to enable all educational institutions to experience the internet and reach for the Cloud – universal student access is the immediate priority, integrated participation is the inevitable concomitant.

For digitisation is not just central to the debate on effective and equitable education worldwide: it is the debate. Considerations of, for example, Sustainable Development goals, universalisation, student assessment, vocational skills development along with personal fulfilment and enjoyment make sense only in the context of digitisation. Young people's lives are founded upon not only a vast and expanding range of ever-more-amazing computerised devices but also the encompassing digital environment, to an extent that earlier generations missed out on. Education, inevitably taking account of and applying this energy, is becoming not just more effective but different in its essence. And this crucial recognition depends upon an appreciation of *The School*.

The School is the rural school for hungry children in disadvantaged areas of Haiti, Burundi and Nepal. It is the fee-paying college serving the sons and daughters of prosperous parents in a leafy suburb of any European capital or resort. It is the academy for teenage would-be computer engineers and specialist doctors in Johannesburg, Beijing and New York. It is the mixed-age class run in tents by volunteers for up-to-sixth-generation juveniles in refugee camps from Aqabat Jaber on the West Bank through Nauru by way of Lesbos on to Dadaab and Darfur. It is Moriah College in Sydney and Dawakin Tofa Science Secondary School in Kano State and Kings School in Cardiff and the

reformatory for young offenders in Abu Dhabi and the second-chance street school for dropouts in Dhaka or for rascals in Port Moresby.

It is the school around the corner, continually reappearing in unprecedented configurations - it is all forms of educational institutions, everywhere. It is not the "school of the future." It is the "whole school approach" made manifest for the digital age – for the present continuous "now." Its essential components include:

- Learners: active, engaged, for life, committed to personal development, information and digitally literate, mobile, collaborating, sharing their learning globally – speaking up across the world;
- Connectivity: rapid, reliable, uninterrupted and affordable (free) access;
- Teachers: well-prepared (academically and digitally) and well-led professional educators, delivering, facilitating and assessing digitally-supported learning, and guiding, supporting and counselling the learners, sharing their teaching materials globally;
- Devices: appropriate mobile appliances for every learner (as there will be rapid changes in handling, versatility, on-line support methodologies and cost minimisation);
- Software: attractive, contemporary and proven learning modules (with teachers' guides) at all levels in all subjects in every relevant language plus background materials, further reading, self- and teacher-administered-tests (but similarly unspecifiable here, as there will be a massive surge in the availability and ineffable variety in the nature of such materials);

- Inclusion: all learners, full- and part-time, on-campus and distant, irrespective of age, gender, beliefs, abilities or disabilities, are welcomed and individually catered for; and
- System: geared to optimising learning through, for example, exemplary school leadership, continuous professional development of teachers, participation of family and community, accreditation of curricula and qualifications, extra-curricular activities (sport, drama, service organisations and very definitely debating), careers guidance and progress to higher, further and lifelong education.

The challenge is not to improve education in and for this Digital Age – the necessity is to reinvent it for our times. While there is some value in applying ICT as a cross-sectoral enabler (e.g. as one of many components in an educational intervention) or as a tool within an organisation for better service delivery and outcomes (e.g. as an Educational Management Information System or in efficient textbook production and delivery), the absolute priority is for all learners worldwide to participate in *The School*. Connectivity is the aim: firstly and fundamentally, worldwide electronic linkage; secondly and essentially, universal exchanges of information and ideas, through text, through picture, through music and, above all, through the human voice.

Spoken Consequences

The notion of *The (universal) School* has profound curricula and pedagogic implications. A central consequence is that learners will necessarily be questioning, expressing their ideas aloud and responding clearly and cogently. Watch young people now with their ever-evolving devices: yes, they text, assuredly they snap (in the sense of taking a photograph) as they chat, but above all, they speak.

And this evolving interchange reflects the emerging learning process. Education is, after two millennia, becoming oral again. Learning becomes the on-going international debate, involving all participants – not just the competitive few along with the vocally challenged minority.

Obviously, the internet offers an overwhelming wealth of information for debaters, with an overabundance of reference material ranging from the speciously bogus to the stimulating authentic. It also offers opportunities for international debates – not just online contests (although these are already occurring) but debates betwixt students in, for instance, New England USA, New England Australia and Old England UK on matters historical, geographical economic, chemical or mathematical. (I note from the internet that I am by far not the only person to have compiled an article designated something along the lines of “Debating Across the Curriculum” (Douse, 2009).) Far more than that, digitisation heralds a fresh educational era. The emphasis will be upon personalised elearning and increasing engagement, characterised by ongoing and creative spoken communication. The fundamental pedagogy will be well-informed exchanges of ideas as the educational process increasingly mirrors the academic debate.

Over nineteen centuries ago, the Roman rhetorician Quintilian entitled his analysis of the formal learning process as “The Education of An Orator” by Marcus Fabius Quintilianus (Watson, 1856). He laid out the educational process step by step and discussed many issues of education that are still relevant today and his work still repays study. For example, Quintilian’s most arresting point about the growing orator is that he should be educated in morality above all else: he quite literally believed that an evil person could not be an

orator, "...for the orator's aim is to carry conviction, and we trust those only whom we know to be worthy of our trust" (*ibid* p.52).

Although assertions of that nature may well be contested, and although Quintilian was focusing on the sons of patrician families – he published no advice on the education of girls (the orator was invariably "he") nor, indeed the offspring of plebeians, let alone of slaves – his work recognises the central role of public speaking in the Roman governance and legal processes. Perhaps a study of 21st century schooling might be titled "The Education of a Negotiator *cum* Outspoken Consumer *cum* Participative Citizen *cum* Vociferous Worker'."

And so, while it might be a trifle too extreme to emulate Quintilian in defining the purpose of 21st century schooling as "The Education of a Debater," ensuring that all school-leavers are able confidently to express themselves through the spoken word, and to present a case and refute that put forward by others, is a reasonable and achievable objective. Its full accomplishment entails a fresh assessment of how everything dealt with at schools and universities is prepared, presented, responded to, recorded and assessed. The Digital Age makes this not only conceivable but, thankfully, unavoidable. A good start would be the realisation that fostering effective oral communication skills by means of the well-informed debate is a priority for all our students rather than just for this minority who are keen to enter contests and that minority who have discernible speech defects.

Conclusion

In his 2014 text *Sparkling the Debate: How to Create a Debate Program*, Snider expressed the hope that, in relation to "...disseminating the value of reasoned discourse... The time seems right to strike some

sparks wherever we can in the hope that it will create additional light." [Echoes of Quintilian may be detected here.] Digitisation demonstrates that the time is entirely right for such sparks to fly. Although I have focussed (in this article and for most of my career) on the secondary stage, I contend that the transformation applies to all educational phases from nursery through post-doctoral to lifelong-learning. The structured academic argument, hitherto regarded by many as a valuable add-on for the interested few, becomes the prevalent pedagogy. With digitisation as catalyst, the debate now manifests the learning process. Proposition, Opposition, Synthesis: the hour is nigh.

References

- Bercow, J. (2008). *Review of Services for Children and Young People (0-19) with Speech, Language and Communication Needs*, Department for Children, Schools and Families Publications, Nottingham, UK: www.dcsf.gov.uk/bercowreview.
- Douse, M. (2009). *Speaking About the Curriculum*, paper to first national conference on "The Spoken Word," Kingston University, September 2009; available on British Broadcasting Corporation archives.
- Douse, M. (2014). *An Enjoyment of Education*. Saarbrücken, Germany: Lambert Academic Publishing, April 2014.
- Douse, M. (2016). *Digitisation and the School*, NORRAG, posted on September 12, 2016 by norrag: <https://norrag.wordpress.com/2016/09/12/digitisation-and-the-school/>.
- Duffin, F. (2005). *Latitudes in Learning*, privately published paper, quoted in Snider, A.C. (2012). *Debate: Key to better academic achievement*,

- Vermont Quarterly*, University of Vermont: <http://debate.uvm.edu/debateblog/wdi/Welcome.html>.
- Mezuk, B. (2009). Urban debate and high school educational outcomes for African American males: The case of the Chicago debate league. *Journal of Negro Education*, 78(3), 290-304.
- National Forensic League. (2015). *Scholastic Benefits of Speech and Debate Activities*, available at: www.nflonline.org.
- Snider, A and Schnurer, M, *Many Sides: Debate Across the Curriculum*, New York: iDebate Press, 2006.
- Snider, A.C. (2012). Debate: Key to better academic achievement. *Vermont Quarterly*, University of Vermont: <http://debate.uvm.edu/debateblog/wdi/Welcome.html>.
- Snider, A. C. (2014) *Sparkling the Debate: How to Create a Debate Program*. New York: International Debate Education Association.
- Watson, J. S. ed (1856) *Quintilian's Institutes of Oratory; Education of an Orator*; originally by Marcus Fabius Quintilianus (circa 60 AD); translated and edited by Watson: London: G. Bell and Sons.

Mike Douse currently advises the European Commission on its support for education in developing countries. He has worked in international development education since 1964, in over 60 countries, as teacher, head teacher, educational administrator and education professor and has been involved in debating and public speaking throughout this period, having (in 1972) organised the first Australian School Students Debating Championships, a forerunner of the World School Students Championships.

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Cross Examination Debate Association and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.